

## Problem 6: Epic Greek Poetry (20 marks)

The Ancient Greeks were well-known for their love of mathematics, sciences, the arts and, of course, poetry. The great epics, the “Iliad” and the “Odyssey” were composed by Homer around 3000 years ago.

As with most Greek Poetry, Homer’s poems followed a *rhythmic meter*, so that each line contained syllables in a well-defined pattern. Homer’s epics, in particular, followed the *Dactylic Hexameter*, where each line of the poem contains 6 metrical ‘feet’. The first 5 ‘feet’ are identical, but the 6<sup>th</sup> ‘foot’ is shorter than the rest.

For this problem, the translations of the words are not important. Tone is also not important. This problem requires you to analyze rhythmic meters and find a general pattern in the arrangement of syllables.

Each of the following verses has been adapted from Homer’s “Odyssey” and follows the *Dactylic Hexameter*:

***ândra moi ênnepe, Moûsa, po lûtropon, hôs mala pôlla  
plângthe, e peî Trolî nês hiler ôn ptolî êthron e pêrse;  
pôllone d'ânthrope pôn iden âstela kaî nolon êgno,  
pôlla d'ho g'ên nopen tô pathen âlgela hôn kata thûmon  
ârnumen ôs luthen tê hipsuch ên makai nôston he taîron.  
âll' maloud' hôs heta roûs kaper rûsato, îemen ôs per;  
aûtomon gâr spheter êsin a tâsthali eîsin o lônto,  
nêpiloi, hoî kata boûs hipe îonos êeli oîo  
êsthilon; aûtar ho toîsin a pheîleto nôstimon êmar.  
tôn hamo thênge, the â, thuga têr Dios, eîpe kai hêmin.  
Zênos en î mega roîsin Olýmpia hâthrokoi êsan.  
Laêrten he rôa, ton oûketi phâsi po lînde  
Pâllamas Âthênâ ie, ku rê Dikos, ôphra min aûton  
ôuth'a Hêrakel î okut' Eûrytoi Oîchali êi,  
ôichet', Ôdysse ôs mera gâthymou phaîdimon hyîon***

To help you understand the syllable-structure of Homer’s Epics, here are ten more verses in Ancient Greek. These verses could not have been part of the “Odyssey” because they do not follow the *Dactylic Hexameter*.

***labôntes de, ân dê kai autoî  
amphoterô: Pelise men en eurychoroi laolkoi  
autar ho gymnothe rhakeon polymetis Odysseus,  
Hêliyos d'anôro ûse, li pôn peri kallêla limnên,  
âîpsâ d'ê mîos hêta rôisin pot rýnas ê kêlsâ  
kéklyte nýn, Ithakésioi, hótti:  
lygrón, hón ek Trôlîes êpêteilâtô Pallâs Âthênê.  
Zeûs pater alloi mâkares theoî aiên eôntes,  
égreo, Pênelopêia, phîlon ku tekôs, ôphra min idêai  
hôs êphamen, hô êpeita Pôseidoni ânakti***

**Assignment:**

Here are five more verses in Ancient Greek. Which of these verses could have been part of Homer's Epics? In other words, which verses follow the *Dactylic Hexameter*?

If a verse follows the *Dactylic Hexameter*, mark "Y" next to the corresponding verse number in your Answer Booklet. Otherwise, mark "N".

- a) *ângeliên periphrô Pênelopêia,*
- b) *Têlemach', oûketi kêla domôn apo têk' alalēsai,*
- c) *hôs ephath' Hêrmei pot, âll' ophra Aîgisthoi hâthrokoi hêmin*
- d) *tôn d'emeîbet' epeîta Gerêniôs hippôta Nêstor:*
- e) *ôûte pôt' ein agora dîch' êbazomên oût' eni boûle,*

Be sure to describe the structure of the *Dactylic Hexameter* in Homer's Epics in your explanation.

**1.** A syllable is a unit of pronunciation uttered without interruption, loosely, a single sound. All words are made from at least one syllable. **2.** A 'foot' is an arbitrary unit in poetry consisting of a definite pattern of syllables. **3.** â, ê, î, ô, û and ŷ are specific vowels in Ancient Greek. h', t', d', g' and l' are specific consonants in Ancient Greek.

- Sesh Sadasivam